

Psychographic Message Framing Outperforms Progressive Baseline on Conservative Segments

Evidence from a 3,006-Person Randomized Controlled Trial

Study: Security Officer Messaging Study, August 2025
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Summary

In August 2025, Hoplight tested AI-generated psychographic message frames against the standard progressive messaging approach in a 3,006-person randomized controlled trial. The AI-generated frames beat the human-written progressive frame by **11 to 26 points net** on every conservative psychographic segment. The progressive base held. On populations Democrats lost in 2024, the standard progressive frame produced statistically significant backlash, driving union support down rather than up. Psychographic cuts of the data produced large, patterned differences across frames. Demographic cuts of the same data produced small, noisy ones.

11-26 pts			
Base held			
26 pts	pts	held	3,006
net lift with religious conservatives	net across conservative segments	no erosion on the left	person RCT voter-file matched

Background

The 2024 election post-mortem split into two surface debates: a channel argument (Joe Rogan, TikTok, podcasts) and a strategic-posture argument (the majoritarian vs. base-maximalist false choice). Both missed the deeper failure, which sits at the message layer. Standard progressive messaging presumes the listener processes the world the way the sender does. When that presumption breaks, the listener hears moralizing as condescension, and the message backfires before it persuades.

Psychographic segmentation groups audiences by values, worldview, and cognitive style rather than demographics. Rather than writing one message for a demographic bucket, psychographic framing matches the message to the listener's operating system: what they value, what they trust, what they read as a threat. This study tested whether AI-generated psychographic frames could outperform the standard progressive approach on a real policy issue.

Methodology

Design: Randomized controlled trial with four conditions: three message treatments and a neutral placebo.

Sample: 3,006 US adults (weighted to 3,004), fielded August 19-20, 2025. 60.9% voter-file match rate. Weighted on age, gender, race, education, and party identification.

Partner: Grow Progress, a progressive research and technology firm with proprietary psychographic segmentation (eight values-based segments cutting across race, class, and party).

Conditions: (1) A standard progressive frame, written by senior union communications staff. (2) Two AI-generated psychographic alternatives, designed to resonate with listeners whose moral architecture prioritizes safety, loyalty, authority, and earned respect. (3) A neutral placebo as the control baseline.

Outcome measures: Policy agreement ("many security officers are poorly paid and resourced") and union-support intent (support or oppose the right of security officers to join a labor union).

Findings

1. AI-generated frames beat the progressive baseline by 11 to 26 points on conservative segments

On the policy-agreement question, the AI-generated psychographic frames outperformed the human-written progressive frame by 11 to 26 points net across every conservative psychographic segment. The largest gap: **26 points net with religious conservatives**. The standard progressive frame went negative against the placebo with religious conservatives, meaning it performed worse than showing people a salt advertisement.

2. The progressive base held

Both AI-generated frames maintained support levels among progressive psychographic segments. There was no erosion on the left. The psychographic approach did not sacrifice the base to reach conservative audiences.

3. Standard progressive messaging produced backlash on 2024's decisive populations

On the union-support question, the standard progressive frame drove statistically significant backlash among the populations Democrats lost in 2024:

Did not vote in 2024	-10 pts (backlash)	+20 to +21 pts
Voters under 35	-9 pts (backlash)	+12 to +14 pts
Working class (<\$50K)	-3 pts	+6 to +10 pts

The frame the field defaults to is producing the opposite of the intended effect with the audiences that now decide elections.

4. Psychographic segmentation outperformed demographic segmentation as a predictor

Demographic cuts of the same dataset (race, age, education, income, urbanicity, party identification) produced small, noisy differences across the three message frames. Psychographic cuts produced

large, patterned differences. The frame is the lever. Demographics are descriptive shorthand the field has been mistaking for an explanation.

What This Means for Practitioners

The progressive messaging playbook has a structural problem. It is not a volume problem (not enough ads), a channel problem (wrong platforms), or a courage problem (too centrist or too progressive). It is a frame problem. The default approach writes messages for people who already process the world through a progressive moral framework, then broadcasts those messages to everyone.

Psychographic framing is not micro-targeting. It does not require individual-level data or surveillance infrastructure. It works by developing message variants matched to different cognitive styles, then deploying the right variant to the right psychographic segment. The segments cut across race, class, and party.

AI is the scalability mechanism. Psychographic code-switching is what deep canvassing and relational organizing do at the individual level. Their per-conversation cost confines them to small-scale deployment. AI-generated psychographic framing is the path to that code-switching at the volume and fidelity a national cycle requires.

Study Limitations

This study measured attitudinal shift (policy agreement and union-support intent), not behavioral outcomes (votes, sign-ups, donations). The natural next step is a field deployment testing whether psychographic frames produce measurable behavioral conversion at scale, with voter-file match-back to validate impact on actual turnout and vote choice. The study tested one policy domain (security officer working conditions and unionization). Generalizability to other issue domains requires additional testing, which is underway.

About Hoplight

Hoplight provides AI strategy for labor, advocacy, and mission-driven organizations. The firm's persuasion research program, the Psychographic Message Engine, generates auditable, tunable messaging matched to the listener's cognitive operating system rather than the sender's assumptions. The engine is designed for a recursive refinement cycle: deploy, measure field response, feed results back into the system. Each cycle sharpens the next.

Hoplight is led by Whit Pendergast, a 20-year veteran of progressive campaigns, labor, and advocacy who currently directs AI strategy for one of the largest labor unions in the United States.

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